



Gekko

A free and open source layout engine on which Firefox is based



Mozilla Labs's F1 experiment

Intends to make sharing content part of the browser. Currently supports Facebook, Twitter and Gmail



FIREFOX: What went wrong?

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To put the above question into context we need to take a small walk down memory lane. Back in the day, IE was the only browser around and then from Netscape's ashes rose Firefox, one of the most successful open source projects in history. It was a browser that was more secure, customisable, but more importantly made by geeks, for geeks. Mozilla's Firefox hasn't looked back since then, becoming the browser of choice for anyone who had a little more sense than a featherbrained emu. Internet Explorer's world domination came to a grinding halt and it started losing market share rapidly.

Cut to today and you have a very different scenario. Firefox faces competition on many different fronts. Google's Chrome has come a long way since its initial buggy, crashy days. Opera, which was side-lined for a long time, is back with a bang. IE 9 is supposed to be more secure and most reports around suggest "it's not bad". Then there's Safari; that's it, it's just there. And

A few years ago we waited for it to become the biggest browser ever. Today... not so much

all of them have added extension support which for a long time was Firefox's biggest USP. If you've noticed all of these competitors have slowly but surely broken down each of Firefox's prime features – personalisation, performance, and security.

The reason we noticed something was wrong was because out of all machines operating in the Digit office right now, only one was running Firefox as the default browser. With many of the members of Team Digit being self-confessed fanboys at one point or the other, this was a bit unnerving. Other than that we've had our ear to the ground and caught murmurs of preference slowly but surely shifting away from Firefox. We decided to check up on

some statistics to corroborate our hunch. According to sources such as NetMarketShare, Firefox has been on a steady decline – from a global share of 24.43 per cent in Jan 2010 to now 22.83 per cent in October. Two percentage points may not seem like much, but it translates into a huge actual drop. This is even more glaring when contrasted with Chrome which has been steadily on the rise – nearly doubling its market share in the same period (from 4.63 per cent to 8.50 per cent). On a side note, we'd like to mention unknown but wildcard entities like RockMelt – the new 'social' browser – are also entering the fray. But what about India you may ask? The Indian market is a little slower to react to global trends. The story isn't drastically different. According to StatCounter the market share for Firefox has gone from 32.98 per cent in October 09 to 33.12 per cent in Oct 2010. At the same time IE declined by about 10 per cent, and Chrome gained almost the same. What this could possibly mean is that IE's loss converted straight to Chrome. Could this have something to do with Google placing a full page print ad in India's most widely read daily? And what has caused this small but steady erosion from Firefox to other browsers?

From a usability standpoint, we decided to list out few of the things that go against Firefox in the current scenario.

Speed: We did a "hunt for the fastest browser on earth" some time back on thinkdigit.com (<http://bit.ly/aSY5wx>) that ran contenders through a series of tests and benchmarks including Acid 3, Dromaeo, SunSpider, V8, CSS Selector, PeaceKeeper, JSNES Rendering, real



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